Chapter 3

Water: Our Precious Friend

We need water every day for drinking, cooking, bathing and washing. Farmers need water to grow crops, and factories need water to make things. No living thing can live without water.

Where do we get water from?

Rain is the main source of water. Rainwater fills rivers, lakes and ponds. Some of it goes deep into the ground and becomes groundwater. We take out groundwater with wells and hand pumps.

Some important rivers of India are the Ganga, Yamuna, Brahmaputra, Godavari, Krishna and Kaveri.

The water cycle

The Sun heats the water in seas, rivers and ponds. The water turns into water vapour and rises into the air. High up in the sky, the vapour cools and forms tiny drops that make clouds. When the drops become big and heavy, they fall as rain. The rainwater flows back into rivers and seas, and the cycle goes on again and again.

Very little water for us

Most of the water on Earth is in the seas, and sea water is salty. We cannot drink it or use it for farming. Only a very small part of the Earth's water is fresh water that we can use. That is why every drop of water is precious.

Saving water

In many places, people do not get enough water. Some people have to walk a long way every day to fetch water. We must not waste water.

- Turn off the tap while brushing your teeth.
- Get leaking taps fixed.
- Use the water from washing vegetables to water plants.
- Take a bucket bath instead of letting the shower run.

Rainwater harvesting

Collecting and storing rainwater is called rainwater harvesting. Rain that falls on rooftops can be sent through pipes into tanks, or into pits so that it goes into the ground and fills up the groundwater.

People in India have stored rainwater for hundreds of years. In Rajasthan and Gujarat, people built stepwells, which are deep wells with steps going down to the water. Rani ki Vav in Patan, Gujarat, is a famous stepwell.

Keep water clean

Never throw garbage into rivers, lakes or ponds.

Let's think

1. What is the main source of water?
2. Why can we not drink sea water?
3. What is rainwater harvesting?

New words

groundwater - water stored deep under the ground
stepwell - a deep well with steps going down to the water